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Shasvin

*A Descriptive Grammar of the Language of
the Shasvin Archipelago*

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Notice

The present volume was originally compiled by the Colonial Linguistic Survey Office during the late colonial administration of AR-29G and describes the literary register historically employed throughout the Shasvin Archipelago.

Assessment

Following Evaluation Directive ILB-77-19, the Interstellar Language Bureau has determined that the language described herein possesses characteristics advantageous for restricted operational use. Particular consideration was given to the limited availability of external reference materials, conservative orthographic conventions, extensive historical corpus, and comparatively low incidence of contemporary second-language acquisition outside authorized instructional environments.

Accordingly, the literary register documented in this volume has been designated the normative basis for *Standard Shasvin* (*Saspine Lahapek*), an auxiliary language authorized for use within designated military, intelligence, diplomatic, and associated administrative branches of the Senate.

Readers are advised that contemporary varieties spoken on AR-29G may differ substantially from the standardized register presented herein. Such divergences should not be interpreted as deficiencies, but rather as the expected consequence of independent linguistic evolution.

*Authorized under Directive ILB-77-19,
Office of Auxiliary Languages*

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Contents

1	Introduction	4
2	Phonology	5
2.1	Consonants	5
2.2	Vowels	5
2.3	Phonotactics	6
2.3.1	Syllable Structure and Clusters	6
2.3.2	Phonological Distribution	6
2.3.3	Semivowel Resolution	6
3	Orthography	7
3.1	The Alphabet	7
3.2	Word-final Consonants	8
3.3	Plosives	8
3.4	Rhotics and Sibilants	9
3.5	Word-final Clusters	9
3.6	Silent Consonants	9
3.7	Yod Sequences	9
3.8	Palatalization	10
3.8.1	Breaking Palatal Combinations	10
3.9	Single Vowels	11
3.10	Vowel Combinations	12
3.10.1	Nasalization in Vowel Combinations	12
4	Syntax	13
4.1	Constituent Order	13
4.2	The Noun Phrase	14
4.2.1	Internal structure	14
4.2.2	Case marking	14
4.3	Copular Sentences	15
5	Morphology	16
5.1	Pronouns	16
5.1.1	Personal Pronouns	16
5.1.2	Reflexive pronouns	18
5.1.3	Demonstratives	18
5.2	Nouns	19

5.2.1	Definiteness	19
5.3	Adnominal Modifiers	20
5.3.1	Adjectives	20
5.3.2	Predicative Verbs	20
5.3.3	Possessive Determiners	21
5.3.4	Demonstrative Determiners	21
5.4	Verbs	22
5.4.1	Tense	22
5.4.2	Aspect	22
5.4.3	Negation	23
5.4.4	Tense–Aspect Interaction	24

1 Introduction

Shasvin (*Nahali Saspin*, Shasvin: [naj 'ɕaspm]) is the principal language of the Shasvin Archipelago, a family of *thalassogigantia insularis*, and the associated harbor settlements along its migration route on AR-29G.

Although considerable dialectal diversity exists, sustained commercial exchange, inter-tanayu migration, religious pilgrimage, and long-distance maritime activity have historically maintained a high degree of mutual intelligibility among the major regional varieties. The variety described in the present work corresponds primarily to the prestigious literary and administrative register employed in the tanayu-borne city of Sumi, supplemented where appropriate by observations drawn from neighboring communities.

The origins of the literary standard remain uncertain. While several traditions associate its emergence with the industrial hegemony of Sumi during the early colonial period, no scholarly consensus exists regarding the circumstances of its codification. Some researchers have argued that the standard developed gradually as a maritime koine employed by merchants and navigators operating between the major different Tanayu of the archipelago and then was brought to the harbors when they were founded.

Regardless of its origin, the literary register described in the present work had, by the end of the first millennium After Arrival, become the principal medium of literature, administration, navigation, and interregional correspondence throughout the archipelago.

Owing to centuries of Hiwariist influence, Shasvin, like all other languages of AR-29G, exhibits extensive lexical borrowing from Kupina Hala. Nevertheless, it retains a distinct phonological and grammatical structure that warrants independent treatment.

The present document provides a comprehensive descriptive account of Shasvin phonology, morphology, syntax, and orthographic practice, based upon direct field observations conducted between 1881 and 1888 AA in accordance with the archival and validation standards of the Senate's Interstellar Language Bureau.

2 Phonology

The standard phonology has 45 phonemes—26 consonants and 19 vowels—and is based on the Sumi dialect. Most speakers, however, merge and alter the phonology based on their native language, so they end up using fewer phonemes.

2.1 Consonants

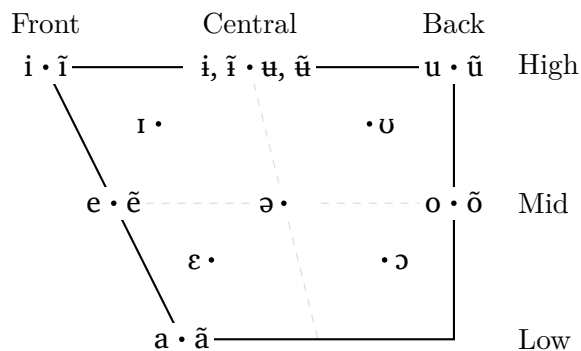
The consonant inventory is presented in Table 1. Note that the alveolar tap [ɾ] will be represented by /r/ in the table and throughout the document for simplicity reasons.

	Labial	Alveolar	Palatal	Glottal
Plosive	p ^h p b	t ^h t d		k ^h k g
Nasal	m	n	ɲ	
Fricative	ɸ	s z	ç ʒ	h
Affricate		ts dz	tɕ dʒ	
Sonorant	w	l r	j	

Table 1: Consonant Inventory

2.2 Vowels

The vowel system consists of strong, weak, and nasalized sets, with two vowels missing a strengthened version. The following vowel diagram illustrates the relative phonetic positions.



[1]: Most speakers merge the high-central rounded vowels /u, ũ/ with their unrounded counterparts /i, ĩ/. Furthermore, many speakers exhibit a secondary merger of /i, ĩ/ with other vowels (such as /i, ĩ/ or /ə/) depending on the surrounding phonetic environment and their respective native languages.

2.3 Phonotactics

Shasvin phonotactics are governed by strict constraints on syllable structure, vowel distribution, and the resolution of unstable semivowel sequences.

2.3.1 Syllable Structure and Clusters

The maximal syllable structure in Shasvin is **CCVCC**.

- **Onset Clusters:** Permitted clusters are restricted to /Cj, Cw/ and the liquid clusters /pr, tr, kr, mr/.
- **Coda Clusters:** Only permitted word-finally. These consist of /s, l/ followed by /p, t, k/, or /r, j, w/ followed by /p, t, k, m, n, ɸ/.
- **Intervocalic Clusters:** Medial clusters allow any coda /p, t, k, m, s, w, l, r, j/ followed by any valid onset, with the exception of plosive-plosive clusters (e.g., */pt, */kd/).

2.3.2 Phonological Distribution

- **Hiatus:** Internal hiatus is strictly forbidden; all adjacent vowel sequences must resolve according to the Vowel Combination rules shown in section 3.10.
- **Vowel Grade Environments:** Strong vowels /a, e, i, o, u/ cannot occur before a consonant cluster. Conversely, weak vowels /ə, ɛ, ɪ, ɔ, ʊ/ are barred from occurring before /ɸ/ or intervocalic /p, t, k/.
- **Lexical Constraints:**
 - **Initial:** A word may begin with any phoneme except /z, ʒ, r/, or the sequence /ʊ/ + plosive + vowel.
 - **Final:** Words may end in any vowel except /ɔ/, or the consonants /p, t, k, m, n, ɲ, ɸ, s, r, l, j, w, ɕ, ʒ, ts, tɕ/.

2.3.3 Semivowel Resolution

Some semivowel-vowel sequences have a specific allophonic resolution.

Sequence	Realization	<u> </u> V	V <u> </u>
/wu, uw, wu, ʊw/	[u]	[wV]	[Vw]
/wũ, ũw/	[ũ]	[ɥV]	[Vɥ]
/ji, jɪ/	[i]	[jV]	[Vj]
/jĩ/	[ĩ]	[ɥV]	[Vɥ]
/ij, ij/	[ɛj]	[i.jV, ɪ.jV]	—

3 Orthography

The Shasvin script can be transliterated with 20 letters that represent its 45 phonemes. This is the byproduct of extensive phonological evolution and frozen orthography. Although it is impossible to know how to spell a new word based on its pronunciation, it is very easy to derive the pronunciation for a new word based on its spelling once you get familiar with the following rules.

3.1 The Alphabet

Letter	Name	Letter	Name
A	ah /a/	L	lal /ləw/
B	pap tof /paɸ to/	M	mam /māw/
D	tat tof /təs to/	N	nan /nã/
E	e /ɛ/	O	o /ɔ/
F	faf tof /ha to/	P	pap /paɸ/
G	kik tof /tɕej to/	R	rar /həl/
H	hah /ha/	S	sas /səɕ/
I	ih /i/	T	tat /təs/
J	ja /jə/ or jaj /jəz/	U	uh /u/
K	kik /tɕej/	W	wa /wə/

Table 2: Shasvin Alphabet (Latin Order)

Special Letter: The letter **Ng** (*ngang* /ka/) is often excluded from the alphabet as it is rarely used. It is transcribed as <ng> because it represented /ŋ/ in Parkjol Saspine (Old Shasvin). It is pronounced /k/ word-initially and is silent elsewhere.

Table 2 uses latin alphabetical order for easier readability. However, the actual ordering of the alphabet is: J, T, N, K, R, F, W, S, P, M, O, U, L, I, A, H, E, B, D, G, NG.

This order is why <jatanki> /jə'tātɕi/ is the word for alphabet, often generalized to writing system, in Shasvin.

3.2 Word-final Consonants

One of the most distinguishing features of Shasvin orthography is the effect of a word-final, silent <e> on final consonants. For each consonant ending <C>, there is a matching ending <Ce> with a different pronunciation. These pronunciation pairs are shown in Table 3.

Letter	<C>	Example	<Ce>	Example
p /p/	/ϕ/	ip /iϕ/	/p/	tihape / ^{ts} ap/
t /t/	/s/	tihat / ^{ts} əs/	/t/	tihato ¹ / ^{ts} ət/
k /k/	/j/	ahak /aj/	/k/	ahako ¹ /ak/
m /m/	/Ṽw/	elmam / ^l ɛlmāw/	/m/	ime /ɛm/
n /n/	/Ṽ/	an /ā/	/n/	ane /an/
s /s/	/ç/	hos /hɔç/	/r/	sese /sɛr/
r /h/	/l/	hadar / ^l hadəl/	/r/	hadara ¹ / ^l hadər/
l /l/	/w/	upal /bəw/	/l/	—
w /w/	/w/	—	/ϕ/	—
j /j/	/z/	ikej / ^l kɛz/	/j/	—

Table 3: Word-final Consonant Alternations

[1]: Sometimes, some morphemes can behave like a word-final silent <e> even if they are spelled with a different vowel, like the -o or ~V suffixes (see §?? and ??).

3.3 Plosives

The letters <p t k> are /p t k/ by default. They aspirate when followed by <h f> except for the case of <pf> /ϕ/. The sequences <up ut uk> are pronounced as /b d g/ when word-initially and followed by a vowel or semivowel, these phonemes are <b d g> everywhere else. These changes are summarized in Table 4 along with some other interactions.

Letter	<_h>	<_f>	<#u_V->	<CC>	<-C#>	<-Ce#>
p /p/	<ph> /p ^h /	<pf> /ϕ/	<upV-> /bV/	<pp> /ϕ/	<-p> /ϕ/	<-pe> /p/
t /t/	<th> /t ^h /	<tf> /t ^h /	<utV-> /dV/	<tt> / ^{ts} /	<-t> /s/	<-te> /t/
k /k/	<kh> /k ^h /	<kf> /k ^h /	<ukV-> /gV/	<kk> / ^{tç} /	<-k> /j/	<-ke> /k/

Table 4: Pronunciation of plosives.

3.4 Rhotics and Sibilants

⟨r⟩ is pronounced as /r/ everywhere except word-initially, where it is pronounced /h/, and word-finally, where it is /l/. ⟨s⟩ is always pronounced as s except in between vowels and semivowels, where it is sonorized to /z/. These rules and some other interactions are shown on Table 5.

Letter	⟨#_⟩	⟨V_V⟩	⟨CC⟩	⟨_h⟩/⟨_f⟩	⟨sr⟩	⟨-C#⟩	⟨-Ce#⟩
r /r/	⟨r-⟩ /h/	⟨VrV⟩ /r/	⟨rr⟩ /h/	⟨rh/rf⟩ /r/	⟨sr⟩ /h/	⟨-r⟩ /l/	⟨-re⟩ /r/
s /s/	⟨s-⟩ /s/	⟨VsV⟩ /z/	⟨ss⟩ /s/	⟨sh/sf⟩ /s/	—	⟨-s⟩ /ç/	⟨-se⟩ /r/

Table 5: Pronunciation of rhotics and sibilants.

3.5 Word-final Clusters

Some clusters can occur at the end of a word due to a silent ⟨e⟩. The only permitted clusters are /s l/ followed by /p t k/; and /r j w/ followed by /p t k m n ɸ/ (see §2.3.1). All other clusters are simplified to only the first sound.

For example, the word ⟨kopfre⟩, originally divisible into syllables as ⟨kop-fre⟩, is pronounced as /koɸ/ and not */koɸr/ as the spelling suggests.

The ending ⟨-lil⟩ will also produce an illegal cluster /jw/ if placed after a vowel. Something like ⟨amelil⟩ suggests [amejw] because ⟨li⟩ becomes /j/ after a vowel and ⟨l⟩ becomes /w/ word-finally. This illegal cluster is resolved as /ju/, i.e. /ameju/.

3.6 Silent Consonants

- ⟨h⟩ and ⟨f⟩ are always pronounced the same. At the start of a word, they are pronounced /h/ and they are silent in all other positions.
- ⟨l⟩ in ⟨Cl⟩ clusters is normally silent. However, it is pronounced as /r/ if the preceding consonant is /p t k m/, except in the specific cases of ⟨tli⟩ and ⟨kli⟩, which are pronounced /ti/ and /ki/.
- ⟨ng⟩ is pronounced as /k/ word-initially and is silent elsewhere.

3.7 Yod Sequences

- ⟨tl⟩ is pronounced /j/, except before ⟨i⟩ as ⟨tli⟩ is pronounced /ti/.
- ⟨nh⟩ and ⟨nf⟩ are pronounced /j/ between vowels, and /n/ elsewhere. In the specific sequence ⟨Vnhe#⟩ or ⟨Vnfe#⟩, the entire sequence is realized as a nasal vowel /Ṽ/.
- ⟨nhi⟩ and ⟨nfi⟩ are always /j/ after a vowel, and /ni/ elsewhere.

3.8 Palatalization

The sounds /t d k g n s z l/ palatalize to / $\widehat{ts}$ $\widehat{dz}$ $\widehat{t\check{c}}$ $\widehat{d\check{z}}$ $\widehat{n}$ $\check{c}$ $\check{z}$ j/ when followed by <j> or <i>, like shown in Table 6. In the latter case, the /i/ sound drops if followed by another vowel (ignoring any silent <h> or <f>).

Letter	<j>	Result	<i> <ih> <if>	Result
t /t/	<tj>	/ $\widehat{ts}$ /	<ti tih tif>	/ $\widehat{ts}(i)$ /
d /d/ ¹	<dj>	/ $\widehat{dz}$ / ²	<di dih dif>	/ $\widehat{dz}(i)$ /
k /k/	<kj>	/ $\widehat{t\check{c}}$ /	<ki kih kif>	/ $\widehat{t\check{c}}(i)$ /
g /g/ ¹	<gj>	/ $\widehat{d\check{z}}$ / ²	<gi gih gif>	/ $\widehat{d\check{z}}(i)$ /
n /n/	<nj>	/ $\widehat{n}$ /	<ni nih nif>	/ $\widehat{n}(i)$ /
s /s/	<sj>	/ $\check{c}$ /	<si sih sif>	/ $\check{c}(i)$ /
z /z/	<VsJV>	/ $\check{z}$ /	<Vsi Vsih Vsif>	/ $\check{z}(i)$ /
l /l/	<lj>	/j/	<li lih lif>	/j(i)/

Table 6: Palatalization Rules

[1]: /d g/ can also be represented by <ut> and <uk> word-initially; the sequences <uti->, <utj->, <uki->, and <ukj-> will palatalize in the same way, yielding / $\widehat{dz}$ / and / $\widehat{d\check{z}}$ /.

[2]: / $\widehat{dz}$ / and / $\widehat{d\check{z}}$ / are pronounced as [$\widehat{ts}$] and [$\widehat{t\check{c}}$] when at the end of a word.

3.8.1 Breaking Palatal Combinations

The phonemes /t d k g n s z l/ can still appear before /j/ and /i i ĩ/ unpalatalized through the use of "breaker" letters:

- **Silent <h> or <f>**: Placed between the consonant and the <i> or <j>. These break palatalization unless they are part of another combination like <thi> / $t^h\mathbf{I}$ / or <anfi> /aj/, i.e. <shi> /sɪ/, not / $\check{c}i$ /.
- **Silent <l>**: Placed between the consonant and the <i> or <j>, i.e. <tlia> /tjə/, not / $\widehat{tsə}$ /.
- **Silent <a>**: Placed between the consonant and an <i>. The vowel combination usually results in the <a> dropping, i.e. <kai> /ki/, not / $\widehat{t\check{c}i}$ /.

3.9 Single Vowels

The pronunciation of Shasvin vowels is determined by the surrounding letters and sounds. Each letter glyph has three possible pronunciations named Weak, Strong, and Nasal. They are pronounced as weak by default and can be strengthened or nasalized based on the proceeding letters.

Letter	Weak	Strong	Nasal	Exceptions
<a>	/ə/	/a/	/ã/	—
<e>	/ɛ/	/e/	/ẽ/	Pronounced /ə/ at end of monosyllables.
<i>	/ɪ/	/i/	/ĩ/	See Note below.
<o>	/ɔ/	/o/	/õ/	<o> is /ʊ/ at the end of a word.
<u>	/ʊ/	/u/	/ũ/	—

Table 7: Shasvin Vowel Grades

Note: <i> /ɪ/ strengthens to /i/ after palatals or silent <l> and is silent between a palatal and a vowel. It is realized as /ɛ/ before coda /j/ and in stressed syllables.

Vowel Strengthening

A vowel strengthens to its **Strong** grade when followed by:

- A silent <h> or <f>.
- The sound /ʃ/ (spelled <pp>, <pf>, word-final <-p>, or <-we>).
- An intervocalic voiceless plosive <p t k> (if the following vowel is not a silent <e>).
- The negative imperfective suffix *-pe*.
- The sequence <nh> or <nf> when pronounced as /j/.
- <a> can strengthen to /a/ in some stressed syllables even if the previous conditions are not met.

Vowel Nasalization

- The sequences <an en in on un> are pronounced /ã ẽ ĩ õ ũ/ unless the <n> is followed by a semi/vowel or part of an <nh nf nli> sequence.
- <nh nf> do nasalize the previous vowel, however, if followed by a word-final silent <e>.
- Word-final <am em im om um> are realized as /ãw ẽw ĩw õw ũw/.

3.10 Vowel Combinations

In Shasvin, any sequence of two or more adjacent vowels is resolved into either a single vowel phoneme or a glide–vowel sequence. Resolution follows a fixed hierarchy of rules applied in order of priority (top to bottom in Table 8). In sequences of three or more vowels, higher-priority rules apply first; remaining combinations are then resolved from left to right.

Pattern	Result	Example	Exceptions	Example
⟨uV⟩	/wV/			
⟨uHV⟩	/wV/			
⟨oV⟩	/wV/		⟨oi⟩ → /i/	⟨ajoip⟩ /əjiϕ/
⟨oHV⟩	/wV/	⟨tofel⟩ /twɛw/	⟨oHo⟩ → /wɔ/; but ⟨oHoX⟩ → /o/	
⟨iV⟩	/jV/		⟨iiX⟩ → /ji/; but ⟨ii⟩ → /i/	
⟨iHV⟩	/jV/			
⟨aV⟩	/V/			
⟨Va⟩	/V/			
⟨aHV _a ⟩	/i/	⟨sahil⟩ /siw/	⟨aHa⟩ → /a/	
⟨eV _a ⟩	/i/		⟨ee⟩ → /ɛ/	
⟨eHV _a ⟩	/i/		⟨eHeX⟩ → /e/	
⟨aHV _o ⟩	/ʊ/			
⟨eV _o ⟩	/ʊ/			
⟨eHV _o ⟩	/ʊ/			

Table 8: Vowel Combination Priorities

V is ⟨a e i o u⟩. **V_a** is ⟨a e i⟩. **V_o** is ⟨o u⟩.

H is a silent ⟨h⟩ or ⟨f⟩. **X** is a vowel strengthening sequence.

3.10.1 Nasalization in Vowel Combinations

The rules for glides and ⟨a⟩-dropping work the same if the second vowel is nasalized. The only exceptions to note for nasalization in vowel combinations are the following:

- If the second vowel of a sequence that resolved into /i/ or /ʊ/ was nasalized, the resulting vowels are /ĩ/ and /ũ/ instead.
- When any vowel is followed by a nasalized ⟨e⟩, the ⟨e⟩ is absorbed and the preceding vowel is nasalized.
 - Example: ⟨o(H)eN⟩ → /õ/ (cf. ⟨tofen⟩ /tõ/)

4 Syntax

4.1 Constituent Order

Standard Shasvin follows **VSO** word order.

- | | |
|---|---|
| <p>(1) aj larruk tokkeful
 əʒ 'lahuj 'tɔtɕəw
 eat snail flower
 ‘The snail eats the flower.’</p> | <p>(2) jut-o utiibi tahrik apa
 jut 'dʒɛbɪ 'tarej 'apə
 see-NPRS woman dress 3POSS
 ‘The woman saw her dress.’</p> |
|---|---|

The indirect object of a sentence is marked with the dative case suffix <-n> applied to the last word of the noun phrase (see §4.2.2) and is generally placed after the direct object.

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>(3) kel ang tof utiibi-n
 kɛw a to 'dʒɛbɪ
 give 1S wood woman-DAT
 ‘I give the wood to the woman.’</p> | <p>(4) pek-o ibi tibi apa-n
 pɛk ɪ'be 'tɛbɪ apã
 speak-NPRS person small.one 3POSS-DAT
 ‘The person spoke to their baby.’</p> |
|--|--|

However, pronouns for the DO and IO—i.e. patientive and dative pronouns—are preverbal clitics (see §5.1.1). This means Shasvin’s word order is more accurately **oVSO**.

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>(5) la= s'=kel ang
 ləʂ'kɛw a
 3DAT= 3PAT=give 1S
 ‘I give it to them.’</p> | <p>(6) la= pek-o ibi
 lə'pɛk ɪ'be
 3DAT= speak-NPRS person
 ‘The person spoke to them.’</p> |
|---|--|

Sentences with multiple verbs generally follow **V₁SoV₂O**, with **V₂** in nominalized form acting as the object of **V₁** and taking its own object as a preverbal clitic or a noun phrase placed after it. If one of the verbs is an auxiliary, however, the word order becomes **oAuxSVO**, with the main verb nominalized and the auxiliary pulling any object clitic to the front.

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>(7) tor ang s'=jut-al
 tɔl a 'ʃjɔtəw
 want 1S 3PAT=see-NMLZ
 ‘I want to see it.’</p> | <p>(8) s'=ahak-o ang kel-al kjol
 sak a 'kɛləw tɕəw
 2DAT=NEG-NPRS 1S give-NMLZ time
 ‘I didn’t give you time.’</p> |
|--|--|

4.2 The Noun Phrase

4.2.1 Internal structure

Noun phrases are predominantly head-initial, with the lexical noun followed by its modifiers, such as demonstratives and attributive nouns. The sole exception to this generalization is a possessor marked with the genitive case, which precedes the possessed noun.

- (9) **utiibi amel-il ipo-ntep tahrik laha ina**
 'dʒɛbɪ ə'mɛjʊ 'ɛpõteɸ 'tarɛj la 'ɛnə
 woman be.pretty-NMLZ 1POSS-GEN dress tall DEM.PROX
 'This long dress of my beautiful wife.'

4.2.2 Case marking

Shasvin noun phrases are marked for three cases: *direct*, *dative*, and *genitive*.

Noun phrases occur in the direct case by default. The dative case is marked by the suffix <-n>, while the genitive is marked by <-ntep>, following the rules outlined in Table 9. Although the table illustrates only the dative case, the same processes apply to the genitive. Orthographically, the genitive looks like the dative form followed by <-tep>.

Word ending	Process	Examples (Base > Case-Marked)
-V ¹	add -n	anfa /'ajə/ > anfan /'ajã/ hoso /hɔr/ > hoson /'hɔzõ/ ²
-C	replace with -n	hadar /'hadəl/ > hadan /'hadã/ tofel /twɛw/ > tofen /tõ/
-Ce	replace with -n	jute /jut/ > jun /jũ/
-C ₁ C ₂ e	replace with -C ₁ in	jarpe /jərp/ > jarin /'jərĩ/ matje /mats/ > matin /'matsĩ/

Table 9: Dative Case Marking Process by Word Ending

[1]: Except <e> if silent.

[2]: The ~V morpheme, which marks indefiniteness in nouns by replicating the vowel in the last syllable and is normally treated like a word-final, silent <-e> (see §5.2.1), is treated as a normal vowel when applying the dative or genitive suffixes, which can affect the pronunciation of the final consonant.

These suffixes are attached to the final word of the noun phrase, which may be a noun, a modifier, or another constituent.

4.3 Copular Sentences

In Standard Shasvin, copular predication is expressed by a verbal negative copula *ahak*, which is the same verb used as a negative auxiliary (see § 5.4.3). Affirmative copular meaning is obtained by negating this verb with the prefix *pa-*, yielding *paahak*. When unmarked for tense or aspect, this affirmative copula is commonly omitted, resulting in a zero-copula construction.

- | | | |
|--|--|---|
| (10) ahak se larruk~ke
aj sə 'lahut̪ç
NEG 3S snail~INDF
‘It is not a snail.’ | (11) pa-ahak se larruk~ke
paj sə 'lahut̪ç
NEG-NEG 3S snail~INDF
‘It is a snail.’ | (12) se larruk~ke
sə 'lahut̪ç
3S snail~INDF
‘It is a snail.’ |
|--|--|---|

Since the copula is a verb, it can be marked for tense and aspect to express other verbal times (see §).

- | | |
|--|---|
| (13) ahak-o se larruk~ke
ak sə 'lahut̪ç
NEG-NPRS 3S snail~INDF
‘It wasn’t a snail.’ | (14) neh se pa-ahak-al larruk~ke
ne sə 'pakəw 'lahut̪ç
FUT 3S NEG-NEG-NMLZ snail~INDF
‘It will be a snail.’ |
|--|---|

5 Morphology

5.1 Pronouns

5.1.1 Personal Pronouns

Shasvin pronouns can be marked for four cases: Agentive (AGT), Patientive (PAT), Dative (DAT), and Genitive (GEN). Agentive and genitive pronouns are stressed words that have different versions for singular and plural, while patientive and dative pronouns are preverbal clitics and do not make a number distinction. Table 10 excludes genitive pronouns since they are just the agentive ones with a suffix applied and will be addressed later.

		AGT			PAT	DAT
Person	Type	Sg.	Pl. (Exc)	Pl. (Inc)		
1st	—	<i>ang</i> /a/	<i>ane</i> /an/	<i>anak</i> / ^l anəj/	<i>n(a)</i> /n(ə)/	<i>j(u)</i> /j(ʊ)/
2nd	Casual	<i>ngak</i> /kaj/	<i>akje</i> /a ^l tɕ/		<i>ng(a)</i> /k(ə)/	<i>s(u)</i> /s(ʊ)/
	Formal	<i>ip</i> /i ^l ɸ/	<i>pip</i> /pi ^l ɸ/		<i>i(p)</i> /ɪ~i ^l ɸ/	<i>l(a)</i> /l(ə)/
3rd	Animate ^a	<i>ina</i> / ^l ɛnə/ ~ <i>ila</i> / ^l ɛlə/			<i>up(a)</i> /b(ə)/	
	Inanimate	<i>se</i> /sə/	<i>sese</i> /sɛr/		<i>s(a)</i> /s(ə)/	<i>e(k)</i> /ɛ(j)/

^a There are no agentive animate third-person pronouns; demonstratives are used instead (see §5.1.3).

Table 10: Shasvin Personal Pronouns by Person, Number, Case, Formality, and Animacy.

Pronominal clitics are written as separate words but phonologically attach to the verb, forming a single prosodic word. Optional vowels in clitics are used only if the resulting word would break a phonotactic rule without it; otherwise, they are dropped. Similarly, *ek* drops <k> before another consonant and *ip* drops <p> in all environments except before <i> or <j>. These reduced forms are indicated with an apostrophe in place of the dropped letter and following space, as in sentence 15.

The agentive and patientive cases are used for the agent and the patient of a transitive verb respectively. Shasvin pronouns follow **active-stative alignment** since the subject of an intransitive verb can be marked with the agentive case to indicate a degree of volition, or with the patientive case to indicate the lack thereof.

- | | | |
|--|---|--|
| <p>(15) up'=jut-o ang</p> <p> bjut a</p> <p> 3PAT=see-NPRS 1S.AGT</p> <p> ‘I saw them.’</p> | <p>(16) na= las-o</p> <p> nə'lər</p> <p> 1PAT= lose-NPRS</p> <p> ‘I lost.’</p> | <p>(17) las-o ang</p> <p> lər a</p> <p> lose-NPRS 1S.AGT</p> <p> ‘I lost on purpose.’</p> |
|--|---|--|

The order for pronouns in a ditransitive sentence is **DAT-PAT-V-AGT**.

- (18) **sa= pek ila ibi-n** (19) **ju= s'=pek ila**
 sə'pɛj 'ɛlə i'bĩ ju's'pɛj 'ɛlə
 3PAT= say DEM person-DAT 1DAT= 3PAT=say DEM
 ‘He says it to the person.’ ‘He says it to me.’

Sentence 18 uses the full form of <sa> because /sp/ is an illegal cluster word-initially. In Sentence 19, the reduced form is used because the same cluster is permitted between syllables (see §2.3.1).

Genitive Pronouns

Genitive pronouns derive from the Old Shasvin construction *A et ep B*—meaning *B exists with A*—which contracted into the suffix -ntep attached to agentive pronouns, yielding the forms in Table 11.

The first-person genitive has the same form for both singular and plural-exclusive.

Second-person genitives do not distinguish formality as the genitive pronouns were formed during an earlier stage of the language, which used *ip* and *pip* as animate third-person agentive pronouns and had not yet shifted their meaning to a formal second person.

Person	Type	GEN		
		Sg.	Pl. (Exc)	Pl. (Inc)
1st	—	<i>antep</i> /'ãteϕ/ <i>anintep</i> /a'ĩĩteϕ/		
2nd	—	<i>ngantep</i> /'kãteϕ/ <i>akintep</i> /a'ṭṭĩteϕ/		
3rd	Animate	<i>intep</i> /'ĩteϕ/ <i>pintep</i> /'pĩteϕ/		
	Inanimate	<i>sentep</i> /'sẽteϕ/		

Table 11: Shasvin Genitive Pronouns by Person, Number, and Type.

Genitive pronouns replace a noun phrase that denotes a *possessed entity*. In Classical Shasvin, they also functioned as possessive determiners, replacing the *possessor*, but this role is now fulfilled by borrowed determiners from Kupina Hala (see §5.3.3).

- (20) **aj-o larruk ipo ngantep**
 əj 'lahuj 'ɛpu 'kãteϕ
 eat-NPRS snail 1POSS 2S.GEN
 ‘My snail ate yours.’

5.1.2 Reflexive pronouns

5.1.3 Demonstratives

Traditionally, the four Shasvin demonstrative pronouns encode both distance from the speaker and distance from the listener, like shown on Table 12. Most speakers nowadays, however, have simplified this into a two distance system with *ina* and *ila*.

	Close to Listener	Far From Listener
Close to Speaker	<i>ina</i> /'ɛnə/	<i>inela</i> /'ɪnɛlə/
Far From Speaker	<i>ilane</i> /ɪ'lan/	<i>ila</i> /'ɛlə/

Table 12: Shasvin demonstratives

These demonstratives can be used in place of objects and people. This latter use is actually the standard way of referencing people as Shasvin lacks dedicated third person animate pronouns. Since demonstratives do not encode number or gender, this usage does not make a difference between one or many people. This is something also seen with patientive and dative pronouns (see §5.1.1).

Because of the implicit distance, *ina* is usually used to refer to people who are present or visible to the speaker, whereas *ila* is used for people who are absent or out of sight.

(21) **ina hadar~a**
 'ɛnə 'hadər
 DEM house~INDF
 ‘this is a house’

(22) **jut-o ang ila**
 jut a 'ɛlə
 see-NPRS 1S DEM
 ‘I saw that.’

Note: Sentence 22 could also be translated as *I saw those*, *I saw him*, *I saw her*, or *I saw them*. These possible meanings are disambiguated through context.

5.2 Nouns

5.2.1 Definiteness

Nouns in Shasvin are definite by default and can be marked for indefiniteness by a suffix that comes from historical reduplication and, therefore, depends on the root's ending. The derivation rules are shown in Table 13.

Ending	Add	Examples
-p, -t, -k	~pe, ~te, ~ke	<i>larruk</i> /'lahuj/ → <i>larrukke</i> /'lahutɕ/
-VV	—	—
-VC	~V ^[1]	<i>hadar</i> /'hadəl/ → <i>hadara</i> /'hadər/ (as if it were <i>hadare</i> *) <i>ful</i> /hʊw/ [hu] → <i>fulu</i> /hul/ (as if it were <i>fule</i> *) <i>seh</i> /se/ → <i>sehe</i> /se/
-CV	~C ^[2]	<i>ibi</i> /i'bɛ/ → <i>ibip</i> /i'biɸ/
-C ₁ C ₂ V	~C ₂ (or ~C ₁) ^[3]	<i>anfa</i> /'ajə/ → <i>anfaf</i> /'aja/ <i>matje</i> /mats/ → <i>matjat</i> /'matsəs/

Table 13: Indefinite form derivation rules based on root ending.

[1]: The ~V morpheme is treated as a word-final, silent <-e>. It changes <-Vm -Vn -s -r -l -j -w> /*Ũw Ũɕ l w ʒ w*/ to /*Vm Vn r r l j ɸ*/.

[2]: If C is <b d g> it changes to <p t k>. If V is <e> it changes to <a>.

[3]: Although <-C₁C₂V> mainly becomes <-C₁C₂VC₂₁C₂VC₁₂ is <l r w j ɸ> and C₁C₂ were part of the same onset in Old Shasvin. If V is <e> it changes to <a>.

5.3 Adnominal Modifiers

5.3.1 Adjectives

Adjectives describe properties of nouns and typically appear after the noun they modify.

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>(23) upal~li utiibi jarpe
 'bəli 'dʒɛbɪ jəp
 come~IPF woman good
 ‘The good woman is coming.’</p> | <p>(24) pe~pek ang hibi laha-n
 'pepɛj a hɪ'bɛ lã
 speak\~IPF 1s man tall-DAT
 ‘I’m speaking to the tall man.’</p> |
|--|--|

Adjectives may also function as predicates in copular sentences, expressing a property of the subject. The omission of the copula can occasionally lead to ambiguity. For example, sentence 25 could also be interpreted as *the small snail*. This is rarely a problem, but the ambiguity can be resolved by explicitly using the copula as in sentence 26 (see §4.3).

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>(25) larruk tibi
 'lahuj tʃɛbɪ
 snail small
 ‘The snail is small.’</p> | <p>(26) pa-ahak larruk tibi
 paj 'lahuj tʃɛbɪ
 NEG-NEG snail small
 ‘The snail <i>is</i> small.’</p> |
|---|--|

Adjectives may also occur without a noun, in which case they refer to “the one characterized by that property.” This usage is common, and some adjectives have developed specialized meanings when used in this way. For example, the adjective *tibi*, meaning “small,” may appear alone to mean “the small one,” but it is also used as the general word for “baby.”

5.3.2 Predicative Verbs

Predicative verbs are intransitive verbs that occur as predicates, expressing a property or characteristic of the subject. To use them as nominal modifiers, they are first turned into a subordinate clause through nominalization (see §??), allowing them to function as modifiers within another sentence.

- | | |
|--|--|
| <p>(27) amel-o utiibi
 ə'mɛl 'dʒɛbɪ
 be.pretty-NPRS woman
 ‘The woman was pretty.’</p> | <p>(28) tihat~hat utiibi amel-il hada-n=s
 'tsətʰəs 'dʒɛbɪ ə'mɛju 'hadãɕ
 go~IPF woman be.pretty-NMLZ house\ -DAT=DIR
 ‘The pretty woman is going home.’</p> |
|--|--|

5.3.3 Possessive Determiners

The possessive determiners in Shasvin were borrowed from Kupina Hala and are used in place of a *possessor* (see §5.1.1 for genitive pronouns replacing possessed entities). They are placed after the noun or noun phrase they modify and do not encode number.

Person	Type	Pronoun (IPA)
1st	—	<i>ipo</i> / ^l ɛpʊ/
2nd	Casual	<i>opa</i> / ^l ɔpə/
	Formal	<i>apa</i> / ^l apə/
3rd	Animate	
	Inanimate	<i>epo</i> / ^l ɛpʊ/

Table 14: Shasvin Possessive Determiners by Person, Formality, and Animacy.

In informal speech, these forms are sometimes reduced by dropping everything after the first vowel. This is accepted in spoken language but discouraged in writing. For linguistic purposes, however, the ellision can be represented by an apostrophe, as shown in sentence 30.

- (29) **la= neh ang kel-al tahrik apa** (30) **jut-o ngak anfa e'**
 lə'ne a 'kɛləw 'tarɛj 'apə 'jut 'kaj 'ajə ɛ
 3DAT= FUT 1S give-NMLZ dress 3A.POSS see-NPRS 2S hand 3INA.POSS
 ‘I will give them their dress.’ ‘You saw its hand(s).’

5.3.4 Demonstrative Determiners

Demonstrative pronouns in Shasvin may also function adnominally as demonstrative determiners. The same demonstrative forms described in §5.1.3 are used in both pronominal and determiner functions.

When used as determiners, demonstratives are postposed to the noun or noun phrase they modify. They do not encode number or gender, and no formal distinction is made between singular and plural referents. They only encode distance from the speaker and listener.

- (31) **ahak hadar ila antep**
 aj 'hadəl 'ɛlə 'āteϕ
 NEG house DEM.DIST 1S.GEN
 ‘That house is not mine.’

5.4 Verbs

Shasvin verbs are categorized into three morphological groups based on the final vowel of the original verbal stem. Although this vowel is no longer present due to historical rebracketing, it continues to condition the form of several verbal suffixes and particles.

- **Group 1:** Verbs whose original stems ended in <a>, <e>, or a consonant.
- **Group 2:** Verbs whose original stems ended in <i>.
- **Group 3:** Verbs whose original stems ended in <o> or <u>.

5.4.1 Tense

Shasvin verbs are in the present (PRS) tense by default and can be marked for the nonpresent (NPRS) tense by the <-o> suffix, which orthographically works as an <e> if no other suffixes are applied.

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>(32) tor ina ip= jut-al</p> <p> təl 'ɛnə iɸ'jutəw</p> <p> want DEM 2PAT= see-NMLZ</p> <p> ‘They want to see you.’</p> | <p>(33) tor-o ina ip= jut-al</p> <p> tər 'ɛnə iɸ'jutəw</p> <p> want-NPRS DEM 2PAT= see-NMLZ</p> <p> ‘They wanted to see you.’</p> |
|---|--|

The nonpresent tense is interpreted as a preterite past in Sentence 33 because the sentence is in the perfective aspect (see § 5.4.4)

5.4.2 Aspect

Shasvin verbs are in the perfective (PFV) aspect by default and can be marked for the imperfective (IPF) aspects with the imperfective particle, which originates from reduplication and therefore varies between verbs. The way to derive the imperfective particle is different for the three verb groups.

- **Group 1:** The rule of thumb is to read the verb as if pronounced exactly as written, then take the final syllable. If this syllable begins with , <d>, or <g>, the initial consonant is devoiced to <p>, <t>, or <k> respectively. For example, *tihat* /tʰsəs/ would give us *hat* /həs/ and *lahabek* /labɛj/ would give us *pek* /pɛj/.
- **Groups 2 and 3:** The final consonant of the verb stem is taken and followed by <i> or <u> respectively. For example, *upal* /bəw/ would give us *li* /i/ and *aj* /əz/ would give us *ju* /ju/.

The imperfective particle can be directly suffixed to the verb, see Sentence 34, in what is called **suffixed reduplication**. If this creates two *distinct* adjacent plosives, the first

one is dropped and the previous vowel is strengthened (e.g., *pek* /pɛj/ → *pepek* /pepej/, not **pekpek*). This is the most common and accepted usage.

Alternatively, the imperfective particle can be used as a clitic that attaches to the end of the sentence, see Sentence 35, in what is called **cliticized reduplication**. Although this is also grammatically correct, it is rarely used outside of colloquial spoken language.

- | | |
|--|---|
| <p>(34) tihat-has ang hada-n=s
 ʔsəthəs a ʔhadāɕ
 go-IPF 1S house\ -DAT=DIR
 ‘I’m going home.’</p> | <p>(35) aj ang larruk~ke ju
 əʒ a ʔlahotɕ ju
 eat 1S snail~INDF IPF
 ‘I’m eating a snail.’</p> |
|--|---|

These sentences are interpreted to be in the present continuous because the verbs are in the present tense (see § 5.4.4)

5.4.3 Negation

Negation in Shasvin is conditioned by aspect and verb type, which means there is not a single formula that can be applied uniformly across all sentences. Verbs are perfective by default (see § 5.4.2), so we will start with perfective negation before moving to imperfective negation.

Perfective Negation Perfective clauses are negated using one of two negative auxiliary verbs. The specific auxiliary to be used depends on the semantics of the main verb:

- **osih** /ʔʒi/ ‘to stop’ — used with verbs of motion
- **ahak** /aj/ ‘to fail’ — used with all other verbs

In addition, the prefix **pa-** /p(ə)/ is used to negate auxiliary verbs, or the main verb in a sentence with multiple verbs, to avoid introducing yet another verb.

- | | | |
|---|---|--|
| <p>(36) osih ang tihat-al
 ʔʒi a ʔsətəw
 NEG 1S go-NMLZ
 ‘I don’t go.’</p> | <p>(37) ahak ang aj-ul
 aj a ʔəjuw
 NEG 1S eat-NMLZ
 ‘I don’t eat.’</p> | <p>(38) pator ang aj-ul
 pəʔtəl a ʔəjuw
 NEG-want 1S eat-NMLZ
 ‘I don’t want to eat.’</p> |
|---|---|--|

Imperfective Negation Imperfective clauses do not use a negative auxiliary. Instead, negation is expressed with the suffix <-(e)pe> /(ɛ)p/, borrowed from Kupina Hala. This suffix inherently encodes both negation and imperfective aspect, and therefore the imperfective particle (see § 5.4.2) is not used in negative clauses.

When this suffix is added to a verb ending in <t> or <k>, the final consonant is deleted and the preceding vowel is strengthened. In all other environments, the suffix attaches regularly, with epenthesis only when required to not break a phonotactical rule.

- (39) **aj-pe** **ang larruk~ke**
 'əjp a 'lahut̪ç
 eat-NEG.IPF 1S snail~INDF
 'I'm not eating a snail.'

- (40) **tiha-pe** **ang**
 'tsap a
 go\ -NEG.IPF 1S
 'I'm not going.'

5.4.4 Tense–Aspect Interaction